

BEYOND THE TEXTBOOK · GUIDE 02

Contact Form with Formspree

Receive messages from your website in your email inbox, with no server and no database.

TIME NEEDED 20–30 minutes	LEVEL Beginner
YOU NEED An email address and the starter files	STARTER FILES <code>examples/02-formspree-contact/</code>

WHAT YOU WILL BUILD

A contact page where visitors type their name, email and message. When they click **Send**, the message arrives in your email and a “Thank you!” note appears on the same page.

How it works

Normally a form needs a **server** and a language like PHP to receive data. Formspree is that server for you. Your HTML form sends the data to a Formspree address, and Formspree emails it to you.

	Step	What happens
1	HTML form	The visitor fills in your form and clicks Send .
2	POST request	The browser sends the fields securely over HTTPS to <code>formspree.io/f/your-id</code> .
3	Formspree	Checks for spam and saves the submission in your dashboard.
4	Your inbox	You receive an email with every field the visitor filled in.

GOOD TO KNOW

Free plan (checked September 2026): **50 submissions per month**, unlimited forms. Plans change, so check formspree.io/plans.

Step 1 Create a free Formspree account

1. Go to formspree.io and click **Get Started** or **Sign Up**.
2. Sign up with your email address and a password (or with a Google or GitHub account).
3. Open the confirmation email from Formspree and click the link to **verify your email**. Formspree only sends submissions to verified addresses.

BE CAREFUL

If you are under 18, create the account with a parent or teacher. Use an email address you check regularly.

Step 2 Create a form and copy its ID

1. In the Formspree dashboard, click **+ Add New**, then **New Form** (the exact label may vary slightly).
2. Give it a name such as **Portfolio contact form** and choose the email address that should receive messages.
3. Click **Create Form**.
4. Formspree shows your form **endpoint**, for example `https://formspree.io/f/xyzabcd`. The last part (`xyzabcd`) is your **form ID**. Copy it.

TIP

You can find the endpoint again at any time under the form's **Integration** or **Overview** tab.

Step 3 Open the starter files

Open the folder `examples/02-formspree-contact/` in VS Code. It has three files:

File	What it does
<code>index.html</code>	The page and the form. This is the only file you must change.
<code>style.css</code>	The look of the form.
<code>script.js</code>	Optional. Sends the form without leaving the page and shows "Thank you!".

Step 4 Paste your form ID

In `index.html`, find the `<form>` line and replace `YOUR_FORM_ID` with the ID you copied:

index.html

```
<!-- Before -->
<form id="contact-form" action="https://formspree.io/f/YOUR_FORM_ID" method="POST">

<!-- After (example) -->
<form id="contact-form" action="https://formspree.io/f/xyzabcd" method="POST">
```

Save the file. That single change connects your form to Formspree.

Step 5 Understand the form code

index.html — the important parts

```
<label for="email">Your email</label>
<input type="email" id="email" name="email" required>

<label for="message">Message</label>
<textarea id="message" name="message" rows="5" required></textarea>

<input type="text" name="_gotcha" class="hidden-field" tabindex="-1" autocomplete="off">
<button type="submit" id="send-btn">Send message</button>
```

Code	Meaning
<code>action="..."</code>	Where the data is sent: your Formspree endpoint.
<code>method="POST"</code>	Sends the data inside the request, not in the web address.
<code>name="email"</code>	The label Formspree uses in your email. A field without a <code>name</code> is not sent.
<code>type="email"</code>	The browser checks that the text looks like an email address.
<code>required</code>	The form cannot be sent while this field is empty.
<code><label for="..."></code>	Links the label to its box, so clicking the label selects the box. Helps screen readers.
<code>name="_gotcha"</code>	A hidden honeypot field. People never see it, but spam bots fill it in, so Formspree ignores those submissions.

When you name a field `email`, Formspree also uses it as the **reply-to** address, so you can click Reply in your inbox and answer the visitor directly.

Step 6 Test the form

1. Right-click `index.html` in VS Code and choose **Open with Live Server** (see Guide 01, Step 1).
2. Fill in the form with your own details and click **Send message**.
3. You should see **“Thank you! Your message has been sent.”** under the button.
4. Check your email. Look in the **Spam** or **Promotions** folder if it is not in the inbox, and mark it “Not spam”.
5. In the Formspree dashboard, open your form's **Submissions** tab to see the message there as well.

GOOD TO KNOW

Formspree may ask you to complete a quick “I’m not a robot” check or to confirm the form the first time it receives a submission. This is normal.

TIP

Test using Live Server or your published site. Some browsers block the request when the page is opened directly from a file on your computer.

Step 7 How script.js works (optional)

Without `script.js`, the browser leaves your page and shows Formspree's thank-you page. With it, the message is sent in the background using JavaScript's `fetch()`:

script.js — the key lines

```
const response = await fetch(form.action, {
  method: "POST",
  body: new FormData(form),           // all fields that have a name
  headers: { Accept: "application/json" } // ask for a JSON reply
});

if (response.ok) {
  showStatus("Thank you! Your message has been sent.", "success");
  form.reset();
}
```

`event.preventDefault()` stops the normal page change, `FormData` collects every field, and `response.ok` tells us whether Formspree accepted it.

Step 8 Add the form to your portfolio

The portfolio from Guide 01 already contains a form. Paste the same form ID into its `action` attribute. You can use one Formspree form on several pages, or create a separate form for each site to keep the messages apart.

Step 9 Publish and share

Upload the folder to GitHub Pages using **Guide 04**, then test the form once more on the live website.

ASK AN AI HELPER (Claude, Gemini, Copilot or Antigravity)

“Add a 'Phone number (optional)' field to this Formspree form with correct HTML validation.”

“My Formspree form shows 'Form not found'. Here is my form tag. What should I check?”

“Explain what `fetch`, `FormData` and `preventDefault` do in this `script.js`, in simple words.”

“Style this form so the button is full width on phones and normal width on laptops.”

Troubleshooting

Problem	Likely cause and fix
"Setup needed: replace YOUR_FORM_ID..."	You have not pasted your form ID into <code>index.html</code> yet (Step 4).
"Form not found" or error 404	The ID is wrong. Copy the endpoint again from the Formspree dashboard.
No email arrives	Check Spam and Promotions. Make sure the email address in Formspree is verified. Check the Submissions tab.
A field is missing from the email	That field has no <code>name="..."</code> attribute.
"Network problem" message	You are offline, or the page was opened directly from a file. Use Live Server or the published site.
You hit the monthly limit	The free plan allows 50 submissions per month. Wait until next month or create a new form for testing.

Safety and good practice

- Ask only for what you need. A name, an email and a message are enough.
- Never ask visitors for passwords, bank details, Aadhaar numbers or other private information.
- Your form ID is visible in the page code. That is normal and safe, but do not paste it in public chats.

Final checklist

- ☐ My Formspree email is verified.
- ☐ `YOUR_FORM_ID` is replaced with my own ID.
- ☐ Every input has a `name` and a `<label>`.
- ☐ A test message reached my inbox.
- ☐ The form works on my published GitHub Pages site.

Appendix: complete code

index.html

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
  <meta charset="UTF-8">
  <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0">
  <title>Contact Me | Formspree Example</title>
  <meta name="description" content="A simple contact form that sends messages to your
email using Formspree.">
  <link rel="stylesheet" href="style.css">
</head>
<body>

  <main class="container">
    <p class="kicker">Formspree example</p>
    <h1>Contact Me</h1>
    <p class="intro">Fill in the form and your message will arrive in my email inbox. No
server, no PHP, no database.</p>

    <!--
    HOW THIS WORKS
    - action   = the Formspree address that receives the form.
                  Replace YOUR_FORM_ID with the ID from your Formspree dashboard.
    - method   = POST sends the data securely in the request body.
    - name=""  = every field needs a name. That name becomes the label in your email.
    -->
    <form id="contact-form" action="https://formspree.io/f/YOUR_FORM_ID" method="POST">

      <label for="name">Your name</label>
      <input type="text" id="name" name="name" placeholder="e.g. Rohan Kulkarni" required>

      <label for="email">Your email</label>
      <input type="email" id="email" name="email" placeholder="you@example.com" required>

      <label for="subject">Subject</label>
      <select id="subject" name="subject">
        <option>General question</option>
        <option>Project idea</option>
        <option>Feedback on my website</option>
      </select>

      <label for="message">Message</label>
      <textarea id="message" name="message" rows="5" placeholder="Write your message
here..." required></textarea>

      <!-- Hidden "honeypot" field: real people never fill it, spam bots often do.
           Formspree ignores any submission where _gotcha has a value. -->
      <input type="text" name="_gotcha" class="hidden-field" tabindex="-1"
autocomplete="off">

      <button type="submit" id="send-btn">Send message</button>

      <!-- Success or error message appears here -->
      <p id="form-status" role="status"></p>
    </form>

    <p class="note">Powered by <a href="https://formspree.io" target="_blank"
rel="noopener">Formspree</a> &middot; Free plan: 50 submissions per month</p>
  </main>

  <!-- Optional: script.js shows "Thank you" on the same page.
```

```

    The form still works without it (Formspree shows its own thank-you page). -->
    <script src="script.js"></script>
  </body>
</html>

```

script.js

```

// =====
// Formspree: send the form with JavaScript (no page reload)
// Without this file, the form still works: the browser goes to
// Formspree's own "Thanks!" page instead.
// =====

// 1. Find the form, the button and the status line on the page
const form = document.getElementById("contact-form");
const button = document.getElementById("send-btn");
const statusText = document.getElementById("form-status");

// 2. Run our code when the visitor clicks "Send message"
form.addEventListener("submit", async function (event) {
  event.preventDefault(); // stop the normal page change

  // Stop early if the form still has the placeholder ID
  if (form.action.includes("YOUR_FORM_ID")) {
    showStatus("Setup needed: replace YOUR_FORM_ID in index.html with your Formspree form ID.", "error");
    return;
  }

  button.disabled = true;
  button.textContent = "Sending...";

  try {
    // 3. Send all form fields to Formspree
    const response = await fetch(form.action, {
      method: "POST",
      body: new FormData(form),
      headers: { Accept: "application/json" } // ask Formspree for a JSON reply
    });

    // 4. Show the result
    if (response.ok) {
      showStatus("Thank you! Your message has been sent.", "success");
      form.reset(); // clear the fields
    } else {
      const data = await response.json();
      const reason = data.errors ? data.errors.map(e => e.message).join(", ") : "Please try again.";
      showStatus("Sorry, something went wrong: " + reason, "error");
    }
  } catch (error) {
    showStatus("Network problem. Check your internet connection and try again.", "error");
  }

  button.disabled = false;
  button.textContent = "Send message";
});

// Helper: write a message under the form in green (success) or red (error)
function showStatus(message, type) {
  statusText.textContent = message;
  statusText.className = type;
}

```

style.css

```

/* Formspree contact form styles (mobile-first) */
:root {
  --navy: #0B2E59;
  --blue: #0B5FBF;
  --cyan: #00B4D8;
  --grey: #5B6B7C;
  --light: #F5F9FD;
  --border: #D7E4F0;
}

* { box-sizing: border-box; margin: 0; padding: 0; }

body {
  font-family: Arial, Helvetica, sans-serif;
  color: var(--navy);
  background: var(--light);
  line-height: 1.6;
}

.container {
  max-width: 560px;
  margin: 40px auto;
  padding: 32px 24px;
  background: #FFFFFF;
  border: 1px solid var(--border);
  border-radius: 14px;
}

.kicker { color: var(--cyan); font-weight: bold; letter-spacing: 2px; text-transform: uppercase; font-size: 0.8rem; }
h1 { font-size: 2rem; margin: 4px 0 8px; }
.intro { color: var(--grey); margin-bottom: 24px; }

form { display: flex; flex-direction: column; gap: 8px; }

label { font-weight: bold; font-size: 0.95rem; margin-top: 6px; }

input, select, textarea {
  padding: 11px 12px;
  border: 1px solid var(--border);
  border-radius: 8px;
  font-size: 1rem;
  font-family: inherit;
  background: #FFFFFF;
}

input:focus, select:focus, textarea:focus {
  outline: 2px solid var(--cyan);
  border-color: var(--cyan);
}

button {
  margin-top: 14px;
  padding: 12px;
  background: var(--blue);
  color: #FFFFFF;
  border: none;
  border-radius: 8px;
  font-size: 1rem;
  cursor: pointer;
}

button:hover { background: var(--navy); }
button:disabled { background: var(--grey); cursor: wait; }

/* Honeypot field: hidden from people, visible to bots */
.hidden-field { display: none; }

```

```
#form-status { min-height: 1.5em; font-weight: bold; }  
#form-status.success { color: #1E8E5A; }  
#form-status.error { color: #C0392B; }  
  
.note { margin-top: 24px; font-size: 0.85rem; color: var(--grey); text-align: center; }  
.note a { color: var(--blue); }
```

About the Instructor

Prof. Prakash Ukhalkar

Educator · Mentor · Machine Learning, AI & Innovation
Pimpri Chinchwad College of Engineering, Pune.

- GitHub: github.com/prakash-ukhalkar
- Website: prakash-ukhalkar.github.io
- LinkedIn: linkedin.com/in/prakash-ukhalkar